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▲ **IN GOD'S OWN COUNTRY** Malabar House in Kochi, Kerala, was the first Relais & Châteaux member in India

The entry process is stringent and takes anywhere between six months to a year. It involves an inspector making an anonymous visit to the property and then recommending it to the board. Average annual membership fee depends upon the hotel's size but tends to be in the €20,000-40,000 range. Members also need to pay approximately a 10 per cent commission on all bookings they receive through the network. Relais & Châteaux itself has a staff of about 100, most of whom work in France, with some based in the US, Italy and Japan.

"We provide nearly 60 different services. Of course, the most important is the use of the brand," says Gardinier who became President this year, but has been a member of the board for 17 years.

And how beneficial are these? "Very", says Yeshwant Rao Holkar of Ahilya By the Sea, a boutique property in Goa. "Interacting with hoteliers from across the globe, cross-pollination of ideas and learning from their experiences is very helpful." They can also use each other's resources. Holkar gives the example of how he invited a Michelin star chef from a Relais & Châteaux member hotel for a charity

event in India. "The Relais & Châteaux brand really counts. Globally it's well established and the guest knows that he/she can expect a certain level of service and experience." However, when it comes to bookings through the Relais & Châteaux site, Holkar says most inbound tourists book via travel agents as they come on a multi-city tour, while Indian tourists book directly through the hotel's website.

Adds Joerg Drechsel who runs The Malabar House in Kochi, Kerala, and has been a member since 2007—the first Relais & Châteaux member in India: "Being a part of Relais & Châteaux is like being part of a private club. There is constant feedback from other members on best practices, on sustainability issues, etc." Also having the brand helps significantly with sales. "For someone coming from the US, UK or Europe, the brand name gives them confidence."

While more than 40,000 people are employed across Relais & Châteaux's member hotels and restaurants, members are facing a shortage of trained manpower. "Maintaining the level of service is a challenge as worldwide we are facing a shortage of people wanting to enter the hospitality industry," says Gardinier.

However, Gardinier says the bigger challenge is sustainability. It's important not only for the hotel but also guests, who themselves are demanding to stay in a more sustainable property. "At every step of the guest experience, sustainable choices need to be made. Whether it is choosing paper over plastic, or offering local food, or having gender equality of staff or saving water," Gardinier says in the beginning sustainable choices are more expensive. "The challenge that we have is not to introduce sustainability at the cost of reducing quality and to make savings. The challenge is to maintain the same level of quality, but in a different way," says Gardinier adding that in the long term "the strongest economics is to have a happy guest in your hotel". **BT**

@smitabw